

The Cabinet of Astonishing Images

Commercial-safe edition: public-domain beauty and original practice

A daily-bite book for children learning that English description can be magical, comic, precise and strange.

Commercial-safe edition. This version keeps the same daily-bite teaching structure but uses public-domain quotations and original model sentences only.

Commercial-safe note: this edition contains no modern copyrighted Rushdie/Roy quotations. Public-domain source quotations are paired with original explanations and exercises.

How To Use This Book

Figure de style in English is usually figure of speech. In this book we also use literary device, because the techniques include metaphor, simile, personification, sound, rhythm, invented naming, colour, contrast and point of view.

Each daily bite follows the same order: first the beautiful sentence, then what it means, then the device, then three exercises. The child should never copy the original wording into their own story. They should copy the move, then change the subject completely.

The best answers are not the weirdest answers. A good image must reveal character, emotion, weather, landscape or atmosphere.

Contents

Original image models: days 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 65, 66, 67, 68, 69, 70, 71, 72

People and character: days 9, 13, 27, 28, 29, 34, 40, 45

Landscape and weather: days 10, 11, 12, 21, 24, 30, 36, 38, 43, 49, 50, 51

Emotion: days 14, 15, 25, 26, 35, 39, 42, 46, 47, 48

Rooms and objects: days 16

Memory and secrets: days 17

Rooms and houses: days 18, 20, 23, 44, 52, 53, 54, 55

Comic strangeness: days 19, 62, 63, 64

Eyes and looking: days 22, 33

Openings and rules: days 31

Sound and voice: days 32, 56, 57

Sound and movement: days 37

Memory and dreams: days 41, 58, 59, 60, 61

Day 1: History as a coat

Original image models

"The family history hung on him like a coat two sizes too heavy."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: Family history feels like a burden on the body.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor.

Why it is memorable: The image is easy to imitate because it turns the past into clothing.

Reusable frame: The [past/family rule/reputation] hung on him/her like [heavy clothing].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: being trapped by expectation.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three wearable images for expectation.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a child burdened by a family reputation.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 2: Memory in jars

Original image models

"Grandmother kept memories in invisible jars, each one sharper when opened."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: Memories are preserved and released.

Figure of speech / literary device: Memory as stored object.

Why it is memorable: A hidden feeling becomes something bottled and opened.

Reusable frame: [Person] kept [abstract noun] in invisible [containers].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: memory, guilt or pride as stored objects.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Invent containers for jealousy, courage and shame.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a family memory being opened at dinner.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 3: City inside

Original image models

"To understand him, you had to unfold the city he carried inside."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: A person contains a whole place.

Figure of speech / literary device: Inner world metaphor.

Why it is memorable: Understanding becomes the action of unfolding a hidden map.

Reusable frame: To understand [person], you had to [open/unfold/unlock] the [place] inside.

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: understanding a complicated person.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three actions for understanding someone: unlock, unroll, listen through.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a person who seems to carry another place inside.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 4: Sulking heat

Original image models

"It was a sulking heat, pressing its face against every window."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: The heat behaves like a moody person.

Figure of speech / literary device: Personification.

Why it is memorable: Weather becomes comic and oppressive at the same time.

Reusable frame: It was a [mood] [weather], [human action].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making weather feel alive.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Create jealous rain, nosy wind and embarrassed snow.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe the weather before an argument.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 5: Examgrey walls

Original image models

"The walls had turned examgrey by morning."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: The colour carries mood, not just shade.

Figure of speech / literary device: Compound colour.

Why it is memorable: The invented colour fuses place and feeling.

Reusable frame: [event/emotion][colour] [object]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: inventing mood-colours.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Make five compound colours for school emotions.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a classroom before a test using two invented colours.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 6: Rainblue eyes

Original image models

"Her rainbluerain eyes looked ready to spill."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: The eyes seem wet and emotional.

Figure of speech / literary device: Colour-folding.

Why it is memorable: The repeated colour creates a flicker and a threat of tears.

Reusable frame: [colour][colour][colour] [feature]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: describing eyes without a flat colour.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Fold colours for anger, kindness and secrecy.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe eyes that nearly reveal sadness.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 7: Button-Button Man

Original image models

"They called him Button-Button Man because his coat had more rules than he did."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: Children name an adult through a visible detail.

Figure of speech / literary device: Child-made naming.

Why it is memorable: The repeated object makes the nickname comic and memorable.

Reusable frame: [Object]-[Object] [Person], because [reason].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: naming an adult through a child's eye.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Invent names for a strict teacher, a noisy neighbour and a nervous visitor.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Write a scene where children privately rename an adult.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 8: Squarely ashamed

Original image models

"He stood squarely ashamed in the doorway."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: The shame affects the whole shape of his body.

Figure of speech / literary device: Surprising adverb.

Why it is memorable: The adverb gives the emotion posture.

Reusable frame: [person] stood [strange adverb] [emotion] in the [place].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: using a physical adverb for emotion.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Replace very with strange adverbs: stiffly proud, damply guilty, brightly afraid.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe embarrassment using a surprising adverb.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 9: Scrooge in seven blows

People and character

"a squeezing, wrenching, grasping, scraping, clutching, covetous old sinner"

Original spark: Charles Dickens, A Christmas Carol (1843)

What it literally means: The character is greedy and hard before we are told a story about him.

Figure of speech / literary device: Alliteration and piling verbs.

Why it is memorable: The sentence feels like a hand grabbing money again and again.

Reusable frame: a [verb-ing], [verb-ing], [verb-ing] sort of [person]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing greed, vanity or meanness without naming it.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find five actions that reveal the trait before naming the person.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Introduce a greedy visitor using a pile of verbs.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 10: Fog takes over

Landscape and weather

"Fog everywhere"

Original spark: Charles Dickens, Bleak House (1853)

What it literally means: The weather fills the whole world.

Figure of speech / literary device: Repetition.

Why it is memorable: Two words make atmosphere feel enormous.

Reusable frame: [Noun] everywhere.

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: letting one thing dominate a place.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Choose one smell, colour or sound and make it seem everywhere.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a school corridor overtaken by one sound.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 11: The world as a line

Landscape and weather

"a long black horizontal line"

Original spark: Charles Dickens, Great Expectations (1861)

What it literally means: A distant landscape is reduced to one clean visual mark.

Figure of speech / literary device: Shape and colour.

Why it is memorable: The reader sees it instantly because the image is simple.

Reusable frame: a [length] [colour] [shape] of [place]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: turning landscape into geometry.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Describe a forest, river and city skyline as shapes.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Open a journey scene with one faraway line.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 12: The weather as a blank page

Landscape and weather

"a pale blank of mist and cloud"

Original spark: Charlotte Bronte, Jane Eyre (1847)

What it literally means: The sky is empty, pale and dull.

Figure of speech / literary device: Visual metaphor.

Why it is memorable: The weather becomes a page with nothing written on it.

Reusable frame: a [colour] blank of [weather]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing boredom or loneliness through a view.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three objects that could represent empty weather.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a window view that matches a lonely child.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 13: The misanthrope's paradise

People and character

"a perfect misanthropist's heaven"

Original spark: Emily Bronte, Wuthering Heights (1847)

What it literally means: A bleak place is ideal for someone who dislikes people.

Figure of speech / literary device: Paradox.

Why it is memorable: The joke depends on matching a place to a strange personality.

Reusable frame: a perfect [type of person]'s heaven

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: defining a place through the person who would love it.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Invent heavens for a gossip, a coward and a show-off.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a room that reveals who would enjoy it.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 14: Fear arrives like weather

Emotion

"the intense horror of nightmare came over me"

Original spark: Emily Bronte, Wuthering Heights (1847)

What it literally means: Fear moves onto the narrator like weather or a shadow.

Figure of speech / literary device: Emotion as movement.

Why it is memorable: The feeling does not sit still; it arrives and covers the body.

Reusable frame: the [emotion] of [image] came over me

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing an emotion arriving.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Write three emotions that move over, under or through someone.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe panic arriving before a performance.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 15: The dream collapses

Emotion

"the beauty of the dream vanished"

Original spark: Mary Shelley, Frankenstein (1818)

What it literally means: Hope disappears suddenly.

Figure of speech / literary device: Abstract contrast.

Why it is memorable: A beautiful abstract thing is made fragile enough to vanish.

Reusable frame: the beauty of the [hope/dream/plan] vanished

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: turning excitement into dread.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three verbs for hope disappearing: cracked, curdled, drained.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe the moment good news becomes frightening.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 16: Scent before sight

Rooms and objects

"the rich odour of roses"

Original spark: Oscar Wilde, The Picture of Dorian Gray (1890)

What it literally means: The room is introduced through smell.

Figure of speech / literary device: Sensory imagery.

Why it is memorable: Scent makes the scene feel luxurious before anything happens.

Reusable frame: the [texture] odour of [thing]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: opening a scene with smell.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

List three smells for wealth, secrecy and fear.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a room by smell before sight.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 17: Life as coloured thread

Memory and secrets

"scarlet threads of life"

Original spark: Oscar Wilde, The Picture of Dorian Gray (1890)

What it literally means: Life becomes something red, woven and difficult to untangle.

Figure of speech / literary device: Colour metaphor.

Why it is memorable: The colour makes the abstract idea visible.

Reusable frame: [colour] threads of [abstract noun]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: turning guilt, hope or envy into thread.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Invent thread images for jealousy, courage and shame.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Write four lines where guilt appears as a coloured thread.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 18: Ordinary building, sinister adjective

Rooms and houses

"a certain sinister block of building"

Original spark: Robert Louis Stevenson, Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde (1886)

What it literally means: An ordinary building feels threatening.

Figure of speech / literary device: Loaded adjective.

Why it is memorable: One sharp adjective changes bricks into danger.

Reusable frame: a certain [threatening adjective] [ordinary object]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making an ordinary thing ominous.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find five adjectives that make a door feel dangerous.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a cupboard as if it might know something.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 19: The impossible grin

Comic strangeness

"a grin without a cat"

Original spark: Lewis Carroll, Alice's Adventures in Wonderland (1865)

What it literally means: The smile remains after the creature has gone.

Figure of speech / literary device: Comic impossibility.

Why it is memorable: The image is unforgettable because it detaches an effect from its owner.

Reusable frame: a [feature] without a [owner]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a funny magical image.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Invent three impossible leftovers: a voice without a mouth, a shadow without a body.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Write a magical image for a corridor after someone leaves.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 20: Castle as prison

Rooms and houses

"The castle is a veritable prison"

Original spark: Bram Stoker, Dracula (1897)

What it literally means: The building feels like a trap.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor of place.

Why it is memorable: The place is renamed as the feeling it creates.

Reusable frame: The [place] is a veritable [trap/image].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a place reveal fear.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Rename a classroom, lift and waiting room as traps.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a house that feels as if it will not let you leave.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 21: Forest as sea

Landscape and weather

"a sea of green tree tops"

Original spark: Bram Stoker, Dracula (1897)

What it literally means: A mass of trees becomes water.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor and colour.

Why it is memorable: The landscape suddenly feels wide, moving and alive.

Reusable frame: a sea of [colour] [things]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: turning a crowd or mass into water.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Make seas out of umbrellas, heads, papers and roofs.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a crowd without using the word crowd.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 22: Sharp eyes

Eyes and looking

"his eyes were sharp and piercing"

Original spark: Arthur Conan Doyle, A Study in Scarlet (1887)

What it literally means: The eyes suggest intelligence and danger.

Figure of speech / literary device: Eye description.

Why it is memorable: The adjectives describe the mind, not just the colour.

Reusable frame: his/her eyes were [adjective] and [adjective]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: describing character through eyes.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find eye adjectives that suggest kindness, suspicion and boredom.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a detective entering a classroom.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 23: A heavy day

Rooms and houses

"a dull, dark, and soundless day"

Original spark: Edgar Allan Poe, The Fall of the House of Usher (1839)

What it literally means: The day is gloomy, dark and quiet.

Figure of speech / literary device: Alliteration and absence.

Why it is memorable: The repeated sounds make the weather feel heavy before the house appears.

Reusable frame: a [sound-linked], [sound-linked], and [silent] day

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: building dread with sound and silence.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Make three weather phrases using repeated sounds.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Begin a gothic scene with one sentence of weather.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 24: Sleepy atmosphere

Landscape and weather

"a drowsy, dreamy influence"

Original spark: Washington Irving, The Legend of Sleepy Hollow (1820)

What it literally means: The place seems half asleep.

Figure of speech / literary device: Alliteration and mood.

Why it is memorable: The repeated soft sound makes the air feel sleepy.

Reusable frame: a [sound-linked], [sound-linked] influence

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: giving a place a mood.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find two adjectives with the same sound for fear, laziness and excitement.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a village or classroom using sleepy sounds.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 25: Weather inside the soul

Emotion

"a damp, drizzly November in my soul"

Original spark: Herman Melville, Moby-Dick (1851)

What it literally means: The narrator feels gloomy inside.

Figure of speech / literary device: Weather metaphor.

Why it is memorable: Mood becomes weather, season and month at once.

Reusable frame: a [weather] [month/season] in my soul

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: describing emotion as inner weather.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Create inner weather for envy, dread and excitement.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a character who looks normal but has bad weather inside.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 26: Ancient instinct

Emotion

"the dominant primordial beast was strong in Buck"

Original spark: Jack London, The Call of the Wild (1903)

What it literally means: An old instinct is waking inside the character.

Figure of speech / literary device: Ancient metaphor. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: The Latinate word primordial makes the feeling sound ancient and powerful.

Reusable frame: the [ancient adjective] [instinct/feeling] was strong in [name]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing an old feeling waking up.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find ancient-sounding adjectives for fear, hunger and pride.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe courage waking in a timid child.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 27: Not fitting in

People and character

"a cygnet is reared uneasily among the ducklings"

Original spark: George Eliot, Middlemarch (1871)

What it literally means: Someone graceful or unusual grows up among people who do not understand her.

Figure of speech / literary device: Animal comparison. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: The image makes awkwardness beautiful, not just sad.

Reusable frame: a [young graceful creature] among [ordinary creatures]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: describing a child who does not fit.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three animal images for not belonging.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a new pupil who seems built for another world.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 28: Time on a face

People and character

"A Face on Which Time Makes but Little Impression"

Original spark: Thomas Hardy, The Return of the Native (1878)

What it literally means: The face seems strangely untouched by age.

Figure of speech / literary device: Personification.

Why it is memorable: Time becomes a force that can press on a face.

Reusable frame: a face on which time had [verb] [effect]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: describing age without saying old.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Make time scratch, polish, soften or ignore a face.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe someone whose age is difficult to guess.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 29: Blunt portrait

People and character

"the most disagreeable-looking child ever seen"

Original spark: Frances Hodgson Burnett, *The Secret Garden* (1911)

What it literally means: The narrator gives a harsh first impression of a child.

Figure of speech / literary device: Comic exaggeration.

Why it is memorable: The bold judgement is funny because it is so confident.

Reusable frame: the most [adjective]-looking [person] ever seen

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a first impression strong.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Write three bold first impressions, then soften each with one human detail.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a character who seems unpleasant at first glance.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 30: A private name for beauty

Landscape and weather

"the White Way of Delight"

Original spark: L. M. Montgomery, Anne of Green Gables (1908)

What it literally means: A road is renamed according to the feeling it gives.

Figure of speech / literary device: Invented place-name.

Why it is memorable: The name makes the landscape feel chosen by imagination.

Reusable frame: the [Colour] Way of [Emotion]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: renaming a place poetically.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Rename three boring routes in your house or school.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a path that deserves a secret name.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 31: Rule with exception

Openings and rules

"All children, except one, grow up"

Original spark: J. M. Barrie, Peter Pan (1911)

What it literally means: A universal rule is broken by one magical exception.

Figure of speech / literary device: Rule and exception.

Why it is memorable: The sentence opens a whole story by making one person impossible.

Reusable frame: All [group], except one, [ordinary truth].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: opening with a broken rule.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Invent three rules with one exception.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Open a fantasy story with a rule that fails.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 32: River music

Sound and voice

"the great grey-green, greasy Limpopo River"

Original spark: Rudyard Kipling, Just So Stories (1902)

What it literally means: The river is large, coloured and slippery.

Figure of speech / literary device: Alliteration.

Why it is memorable: The repeated gr sound makes the phrase comic and sticky.

Reusable frame: the [size] [colour-colour], [texture] [place]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making place-names musical.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Describe three places with repeated sounds.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Give a corridor a ridiculous musical description.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 33: Hard eyes

Eyes and looking

"Bagheera's eyes were as hard as jade stones"

Original spark: Rudyard Kipling, The Jungle Book (1894)

What it literally means: The eyes look cold, hard and dangerous.

Figure of speech / literary device: Simile.

Why it is memorable: The stone comparison makes anger visible.

Reusable frame: [person]'s eyes were as hard as [stone/object]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing danger through eyes.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find hard objects for anger, suspicion and determination.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe someone angry without using angry.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 34: Person as apparition

People and character

"She was a Phantom of delight"

Original spark: William Wordsworth, Poems (1807)

What it literally means: A person seems almost supernatural and joyful.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor.

Why it is memorable: The image turns a person into a glowing idea.

Reusable frame: She/he was a [vision/image] of [emotion]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a person seem magical to the narrator.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find images for someone who seems brave, lonely and kind.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe someone ordinary who appears magical to one person.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 35: Lonely as a cloud

Emotion

"I wandered lonely as a cloud"

Original spark: William Wordsworth, Poems in Two Volumes (1807)

What it literally means: Loneliness is drifting and high above others.

Figure of speech / literary device: Simile.

Why it is memorable: The cloud makes loneliness light, mobile and visible.

Reusable frame: I [verb] [emotion] as a [natural thing]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: turning emotion into movement.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find natural objects for jealousy, relief and embarrassment.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Write three similes for loneliness that are not obvious.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 36: Autumn as a kingdom

Landscape and weather

"Season of mists and mellow fruitfulness"

Original spark: John Keats, Poems Published in 1820 (1820)

What it literally means: Autumn is misty, ripe and full.

Figure of speech / literary device: Sound and abundance.

Why it is memorable: The soft sounds make the season feel rich and heavy.

Reusable frame: Season of [weather] and [adjective noun]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a time of year feel sensuous.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Describe winter, spring and exam season with this frame.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Write about a season as if it were a person arriving.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 37: Speed in sound

Sound and movement

"The fair breeze blew, the white foam flew"

Original spark: Samuel Taylor Coleridge, The Rime of the Ancient Mariner (1798)

What it literally means: Wind and sea move quickly together.

Figure of speech / literary device: Parallel alliteration.

Why it is memorable: The repeated structure makes the movement feel fast and musical.

Reusable frame: The [adjective noun] [verb], the [adjective noun] [verb].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making action musical.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Write parallel lines for running, rain and a crowd.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a playground at breaktime using paired movement.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 38: Bright danger

Landscape and weather

"Tyger Tyger, burning bright"

Original spark: William Blake, Songs of Experience (1794)

What it literally means: The creature is beautiful and frightening.

Figure of speech / literary device: Repetition and fire image.

Why it is memorable: The repeated name and burning light make danger shine.

Reusable frame: [Thing] [thing], [burning/gleaming] [adjective]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: mixing beauty and threat.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three beautiful things that could feel dangerous.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a trophy, knife or bonfire as beautiful and threatening.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 39: Poisoned mind

Emotion

"full of scorpions is my mind"

Original spark: William Shakespeare, Macbeth (1606)

What it literally means: The mind is full of poisonous creatures.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor and inversion.

Why it is memorable: Guilt and fear become alive, sharp and venomous.

Reusable frame: full of [creatures] is my [mind/heart]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing a poisoned emotion.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find creatures for worry, envy and anger.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Write a sentence where guilt crawls inside someone.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 40: Person as sun

People and character

"Juliet is the sun"

Original spark: William Shakespeare, Romeo and Juliet (1597)

What it literally means: Juliet is the source of light and life to Romeo.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor.

Why it is memorable: One person changes the lighting of the whole world.

Reusable frame: [Name] is the [source of light]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a person transform a scene.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find light sources for a kind friend, strict teacher and rival.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe someone entering a room and changing its weather.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 41: Dream material

Memory and dreams

"such stuff as dreams are made on"

Original spark: William Shakespeare, The Tempest (1611)

What it literally means: Reality is compared to dream material.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: The phrase makes life feel delicate, theatrical and temporary.

Reusable frame: such stuff as [dreams/fears/memories] are made on

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making an experience feel unreal.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find materials for memory, fear and hope.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a place that feels too beautiful to last.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 42: A singing heart

Emotion

"My heart is like a singing bird"

Original spark: Christina Rossetti, Goblin Market and Other Poems (1862)

What it literally means: Joy makes the speaker's heart feel alive and musical.

Figure of speech / literary device: Simile.

Why it is memorable: The feeling is not named; it sings.

Reusable frame: My [body part] is like a [living/musical thing]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing joy through an image.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find singing images for relief, pride and excitement.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a character trying not to show happiness.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 43: Dappled things

Landscape and weather

"Glory be to God for dappled things"

Original spark: Gerard Manley Hopkins, Pied Beauty (1918)

What it literally means: The speaker praises spotted, varied things.

Figure of speech / literary device: Sound and praise. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: The word dappled makes beauty irregular, not smooth.

Reusable frame: [Praise phrase] for [patterned/varied] things

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: noticing irregular beauty.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

List five dappled, freckled or speckled things.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe beauty in something uneven or imperfect.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 44: Story holds the room

Rooms and houses

"The story had held us"

Original spark: Henry James, The Turn of the Screw (1898)

What it literally means: A story grips its listeners.

Figure of speech / literary device: Personification.

Why it is memorable: The abstract story behaves like hands around the room.

Reusable frame: The [story/secret/silence] had held us.

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making an abstract thing physically grip people.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three things that can hold a room without hands.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a rumour taking control of a classroom.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 45: Flint character

People and character

"hard and sharp as flint"

Original spark: Charles Dickens, A Christmas Carol (1843)

What it literally means: A person's nature is compared to a hard stone.

Figure of speech / literary device: Simile.

Why it is memorable: The image makes character feel touchable: cold, edged and impossible to soften.

Reusable frame: [quality] and [quality] as [material/object]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing a hard personality through material.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find materials for a kind, vain and jealous person.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a strict character using one material comparison.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 46: No bird, no net

Emotion

"I am no bird; and no net ensnares me"

Original spark: Charlotte Bronte, Jane Eyre (1847)

What it literally means: The speaker refuses to be trapped or owned.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor and negation. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: Freedom is shown through a bird and a net, but the speaker rejects both images.

Reusable frame: I am no [creature]; and no [trap] [verb] me

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: writing defiance without saying defiant.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three creature-and-trap pairs for freedom.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Write a line for a character refusing to be controlled.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 47: Heart as dungeon

Emotion

"what other dungeon is so dark as one's own heart"

Original spark: Nathaniel Hawthorne, *The House of the Seven Gables* (1851)

What it literally means: A troubled heart is darker than any prison.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor and rhetorical question. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: The emotion becomes architecture: inner life turns into a locked, gloomy place.

Reusable frame: what other [place] is so [quality] as one's own [body/feeling]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing shame, grief or fear as a place.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three inner places for guilt.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a character trapped by a feeling inside themselves.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 48: Lonely beacon

Emotion

"like a beacon left alone"

Original spark: Christina Rossetti, Goblin Market and Other Poems (1862)

What it literally means: A person or thing is solitary but still shining.

Figure of speech / literary device: Simile.

Why it is memorable: The image makes loneliness visible and dignified rather than merely sad.

Reusable frame: like a [light/source] left alone

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing loneliness with light.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three lights that can be lonely.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a child alone in a crowd without using lonely.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 49: The heath has a face

Landscape and weather

"The face of the heath"

Original spark: Thomas Hardy, The Return of the Native (1878)

What it literally means: The landscape is treated as if it has a face.

Figure of speech / literary device: Landscape personification.

Why it is memorable: A place stops being background and becomes a character looking back.

Reusable frame: The face of the [place]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making landscape feel alive.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Give a face to a street, hill, school or garden.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a place as if it had an expression.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 50: Sea as burial cloth

Landscape and weather

"the great shroud of the sea"

Original spark: Herman Melville, Moby-Dick (1851)

What it literally means: The sea covers something like a burial cloth.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: The image is vast, solemn and frightening, turning water into ceremony.

Reusable frame: the great [covering/cloth] of the [place/natural force]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making landscape feel grave or sacred.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three cloth images for fog, snow and night.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a landscape after something has vanished.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 51: Light from foil

Landscape and weather

"like shining from shook foil"

Original spark: Gerard Manley Hopkins, God's Grandeur (1918)

What it literally means: Light flashes like crumpled metal being shaken.

Figure of speech / literary device: Simile and sound. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: The image is surprising because it makes light metallic, sudden and noisy.

Reusable frame: like [light/action] from [shaken/crumpled object]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: describing sudden brightness.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three objects that flash when moved.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe sunlight on water, glass or trophies.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 52: Windows as eyes

Rooms and houses

"vacant eye-like windows"

Original spark: Edgar Allan Poe, The Fall of the House of Usher (1839)

What it literally means: The house seems to have empty eyes.

Figure of speech / literary device: Personification.

Why it is memorable: Architecture becomes a face, and the face seems dead but watching.

Reusable frame: [adjective] eye-like [parts of a building]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a house unsettling.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Give eyes to three parts of a building.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a house that seems to watch visitors.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 53: Mythic doorway

Rooms and houses

"a wilderness of crumbling griffins"

Original spark: Emily Bronte, Wuthering Heights (1847)

What it literally means: Old carved creatures make the entrance feel wild and ancient.

Figure of speech / literary device: Mythic visual detail. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: A doorway becomes a miniature ruined world.

Reusable frame: a wilderness of crumbling [carvings/objects/creatures]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a building feel ancient.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three ordinary places that could contain a wilderness.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe an old doorway using mythical detail.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 54: House wearing a cloak

Rooms and houses

"sloping, cloak-like roof"

Original spark: D. H. Lawrence, England, My England (1922)

What it literally means: The roof hangs like clothing.

Figure of speech / literary device: Simile.

Why it is memorable: The house seems dressed, secretive and almost human.

Reusable frame: [shape], [garment]-like [building part]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: describing buildings as clothed bodies.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Give garments to a house, station and classroom.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a house as if it were wearing something.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 55: Prison as flower

Rooms and houses

"black flower of civilized society"

Original spark: Nathaniel Hawthorne, *The Scarlet Letter* (1850)

What it literally means: A prison is described as a dark flower grown by society.

Figure of speech / literary device: Symbolic metaphor. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: Beauty and ugliness collide, making the image morally disturbing.

Reusable frame: [colour] flower of [abstract noun/group]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making an institution symbolic.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find flower images for gossip, ambition and punishment.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a school rule or public building as a strange flower.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 56: Rustling as silk

Sound and voice

"silken, sad, uncertain rustling"

Original spark: Edgar Allan Poe, The Raven (1845)

What it literally means: A rustling sound feels soft, sad and nervous.

Figure of speech / literary device: Sound texture and alliteration.

Why it is memorable: Sound becomes fabric and emotion at once.

Reusable frame: [texture], [emotion], [uncertain adjective] [sound]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: describing sound through texture.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Give textures to whispers, footsteps and rain.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a noise at night without naming its source.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 57: Broken voice

Sound and voice

"husky, whispering and somewhat broken voice"

Original spark: Robert Louis Stevenson, Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde (1886)

What it literally means: The voice sounds rough, secretive and damaged.

Figure of speech / literary device: Voice as character evidence.

Why it is memorable: The adjectives make the speaker's hidden life audible.

Reusable frame: [texture], [manner] and somewhat [damaged] voice

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: revealing character through voice.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find voice textures for kindness, fear and arrogance.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a character speaking from another room.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 58: Bubble of light

Memory and dreams

"a big soft bubble of light"

Original spark: Katherine Mansfield, Bliss and Other Stories (1920)

What it literally means: Light becomes round, soft and touchable.

Figure of speech / literary device: Metaphor and tactile light.

Why it is memorable: The image makes a domestic moment feel delicate and enchanted.

Reusable frame: a [size] [texture] bubble of [light/feeling]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making memory or happiness visible.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Make bubbles out of silence, laughter and fear.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a happy room without using happy.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 59: Tree taps the mind

Memory and dreams

"The tree outside the window taps very gently"

Original spark: Virginia Woolf, Monday or Tuesday (1921)

What it literally means: A tree makes a tiny sound at the window.

Figure of speech / literary device: Personification and sound.

Why it is memorable: The small sound feels like a thought trying to enter.

Reusable frame: The [thing] outside the [place] [small action] very gently

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: using tiny sound to open mood.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find gentle actions for rain, branches and clock hands.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Begin a reflective scene with one small repeated sound.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 60: Dreams in the shadows

Memory and dreams

"forms dreamed of, lurking in the shadows"

Original spark: Lafcadio Hearn, Shadowings (1900)

What it literally means: Shapes in darkness seem like imagined creatures.

Figure of speech / literary device: Dream logic. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: Dreams leak into the room, but the sentence remains clear.

Reusable frame: [forms/things] dreamed of, lurking in the [place]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a room feel haunted by imagination.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three places where dreams could lurk.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a bedroom at night using one dreamlike shape.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 61: Memory in every view

Memory and dreams

"You have been in every prospect I have ever seen"

Original spark: Charles Dickens, Great Expectations (1861)

What it literally means: A person is present in every view the speaker remembers.

Figure of speech / literary device: Memory spread across landscape. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: Memory expands until it covers the whole outside world.

Reusable frame: You have been in every [view/place] I have ever [seen/known]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: showing obsession or deep memory.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three ways a person can appear inside places.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe missing someone through landscape, not tears.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 62: Telescopic eyes

Comic strangeness

"move them in and out like telescopes"

Original spark: E. Nesbit, Five Children and It (1902)

What it literally means: Body parts move like mechanical objects.

Figure of speech / literary device: Comic simile.

Why it is memorable: A strange creature becomes imaginable through a familiar device.

Reusable frame: [body parts] moved like [mechanical objects]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: making a creature funny and visible.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Compare ears, fingers and eyebrows to objects that move.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Invent a magical creature using one household object comparison.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 63: Train as dragon

Comic strangeness

"the Green Dragon"

Original spark: E. Nesbit, *The Railway Children* (1906)

What it literally means: A train is renamed as a mythical creature.

Figure of speech / literary device: Child's-eye naming.

Why it is memorable: The ordinary machine becomes magical because children name it vividly.

Reusable frame: the [Colour] [Creature]

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: renaming machines or vehicles.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Rename a bus, lift and vacuum cleaner as creatures.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a train or car as if a child had named it.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 64: Careless tragedy

Comic strangeness

"to lose both looks like carelessness"

Original spark: Oscar Wilde, *The Importance of Being Earnest* (1895)

What it literally means: A serious loss is treated as bad organisation.

Figure of speech / literary device: Comic understatement. Discuss this one first: the image is more advanced.

Why it is memorable: The joke comes from applying tidy logic to something emotional.

Reusable frame: to [serious mistake] looks like [small fault]

Comprehension pause: What two things are being connected? What feeling does the image create before you imitate it?

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: writing witty understatement.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Turn three disasters into silly administrative faults.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Write a comic line about losing something important.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 65: Late smile

Original image models

"Her smile arrived late, like sunlight finding a locked room."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: A shy person's smile comes slowly.

Figure of speech / literary device: Simile and delay.

Why it is memorable: The delayed smile becomes light entering a closed place.

Reusable frame: Her/his [expression] arrived late, like [light/weather] finding [closed place].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: shyness, guarded kindness or relief.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find three images for a late smile: a curtain opening, a match catching, a bird returning.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a child who wants to be friendly but cannot begin.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 66: Weather frown

Original image models

"His frown had weather in it: low cloud, no birds, the promise of rain."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: The face shows trouble coming.

Figure of speech / literary device: Face as weather.

Why it is memorable: A small expression contains a whole sky.

Reusable frame: His/her [expression] had weather in it: [sky detail], [absence], [threat].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: anger or bad news before it is spoken.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Make three facial weather forecasts.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a teacher before announcing bad news.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 67: Pockets of excuses

Original image models

"His pockets sagged with unposted excuses."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: The person is carrying excuses he has not said yet.

Figure of speech / literary device: Abstract things as objects.

Why it is memorable: Excuses become heavy letters that have not been sent.

Reusable frame: His/her pockets sagged with unposted [abstract plural].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: guilt, lies or forgotten homework.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Invent pocket images for worry, promises and secrets.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a child who has forgotten homework.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 68: The Maybe Door

Original image models

"They called it the Maybe Door, because grown-ups never used it."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: A door becomes mysterious because children give it a private name.

Figure of speech / literary device: Child-made naming.

Why it is memorable: The name is simple enough to remember and strange enough to open a story.

Reusable frame: They called it the [Maybe/Never/Almost] [object], because [reason].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: naming a mysterious place.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Invent names for a cupboard, gate and staircase.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Open a story with a private name children use for a forbidden place.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 69: Kitchen machine

Original image models

"The kitchen was a warm machine for turning worry into soup."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: The room changes emotion into food.

Figure of speech / literary device: Room as machine.

Why it is memorable: A family room becomes useful, emotional and slightly magical.

Reusable frame: The [room] was a [temperature] machine for turning [emotion] into [object/food].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: comfort, family tension or care.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Find room-machines for anger, boredom and celebration.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a kitchen during bad news.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 70: Secret with handles

Original image models

"The secret grew handles; everyone had carried it."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: A secret has become something shared and handled.

Figure of speech / literary device: Secret as object.

Why it is memorable: The image makes gossip feel heavy and passed from person to person.

Reusable frame: The [secret/rumour] grew [parts]; everyone had [handled action] it.

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: a rumour moving through school.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Give a secret handles, teeth, wheels, pockets and a smell.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a rumour before it reaches the main character.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 71: Blue fingerprints

Original image models

"Dusk put blue fingerprints on the windows."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: Evening leaves colour on the glass.

Figure of speech / literary device: Time as evidence.

Why it is memorable: Time behaves like a person touching the room.

Reusable frame: [Time of day] put [colour] fingerprints on the [surface].

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: arrival of evening, winter or sadness.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Make dawn, winter and fear leave fingerprints.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Describe a room as the light changes.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Day 72: Yesterday face

Original image models

"The new boy had a Yesterday Face."

Original model: Original model sentence

What it literally means: The child looks as if he belongs to the past or misses something.

Figure of speech / literary device: Time-label portrait.

Why it is memorable: A simple invented label suggests homesickness without explaining it.

Reusable frame: The [person] had a [time] Face.

1. Find cousin images: Write three other images for the same idea.

Target idea: homesickness, memory or strangeness.

2. Transpose the figure of speech into a new sentence.

Invent faces named after time: Monday Face, Nearly Face, Last-Year Face.

3. Use it inside a tiny description.

Introduce a new pupil using a time-label portrait.

Self-check: Can I explain the device? Is my sentence original? Does the image reveal character, mood or place?

Source And Rights Note

Commercial-safe note: this edition contains no modern copyrighted Rushdie/Roy quotations. Public-domain source quotations are paired with original explanations and exercises.

Public-domain quotations should still be checked by territory before commercial distribution beyond the UK and US. This note is editorial guidance, not legal advice.

9. Charles Dickens, A Christmas Carol: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/46>
10. Charles Dickens, Bleak House: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1023>
11. Charles Dickens, Great Expectations: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1400>
12. Charlotte Bronte, Jane Eyre: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1260>
13. Emily Bronte, Wuthering Heights: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/768>
14. Emily Bronte, Wuthering Heights: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/768>
15. Mary Shelley, Frankenstein: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/84>
16. Oscar Wilde, The Picture of Dorian Gray: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/174>
17. Oscar Wilde, The Picture of Dorian Gray: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/174>
18. Robert Louis Stevenson, Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/43>
19. Lewis Carroll, Alice's Adventures in Wonderland: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/11>
20. Bram Stoker, Dracula: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/345>
21. Bram Stoker, Dracula: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/345>
22. Arthur Conan Doyle, A Study in Scarlet: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/244>
23. Edgar Allan Poe, The Fall of the House of Usher: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/932>
24. Washington Irving, The Legend of Sleepy Hollow: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/41>
25. Herman Melville, Moby-Dick: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2701>
26. Jack London, The Call of the Wild: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/215>
27. George Eliot, Middlemarch: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/145>
28. Thomas Hardy, The Return of the Native: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/122>
29. Frances Hodgson Burnett, The Secret Garden: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/113>
30. L. M. Montgomery, Anne of Green Gables: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/45>
31. J. M. Barrie, Peter Pan: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/16>
32. Rudyard Kipling, Just So Stories: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2781>
33. Rudyard Kipling, The Jungle Book: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/236>
34. William Wordsworth, Poems: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/12383>
35. William Wordsworth, Poems in Two Volumes: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/8824>
36. John Keats, Poems Published in 1820: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/23684>
37. Samuel Taylor Coleridge, The Rime of the Ancient Mariner: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/151>
38. William Blake, Songs of Experience: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/574>
39. William Shakespeare, Macbeth: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/100>
40. William Shakespeare, Romeo and Juliet: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/100>
41. William Shakespeare, The Tempest: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/100>
42. Christina Rossetti, Goblin Market and Other Poems: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/16950>
43. Gerard Manley Hopkins, Pied Beauty: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/22403>
44. Henry James, The Turn of the Screw: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/209>
45. Charles Dickens, A Christmas Carol: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/46>
46. Charlotte Bronte, Jane Eyre: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1260>
47. Nathaniel Hawthorne, The House of the Seven Gables: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/77>
48. Christina Rossetti, Goblin Market and Other Poems: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/16950>
49. Thomas Hardy, The Return of the Native: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/122>
50. Herman Melville, Moby-Dick: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2701>
51. Gerard Manley Hopkins, God's Grandeur: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/22403>
52. Edgar Allan Poe, The Fall of the House of Usher: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/932>
53. Emily Bronte, Wuthering Heights: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/768>
54. D. H. Lawrence, England, My England: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/8914>
55. Nathaniel Hawthorne, The Scarlet Letter: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/25344>
56. Edgar Allan Poe, The Raven: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1065>
57. Robert Louis Stevenson, Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/43>
58. Katherine Mansfield, Bliss and Other Stories: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/44385>
59. Virginia Woolf, Monday or Tuesday: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/29220>
60. Lafcadio Hearn, Shadowings: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/34215>
61. Charles Dickens, Great Expectations: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1400>
62. E. Nesbit, Five Children and It: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/17314>
63. E. Nesbit, The Railway Children: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1874>
64. Oscar Wilde, The Importance of Being Earnest: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/844>